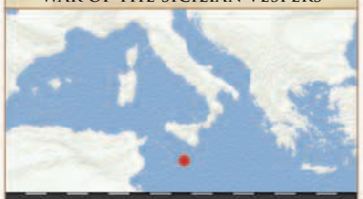
THE BATTLE OF MALTA

The outbreak of the War of the Sicilian Vespers in 1282 set Charles of Anjou, Count of Provence and ruler of Naples and Sicily, against King Peter III of Aragon, whose domains included Catalonia. Initially the Aragonese had the better of the Angevins at sea, so Charles ordered the creation of a new galley fleet at Marseille—to be manned by Provencal crews and soldiers, and commanded by two Marseillais admirals, Guillaume de Cornut and Bartolomé Bonvin. In June 1283 these Provencal galleys arrived in Malta to aid an Angevin garrison besieged in Fort St. Angelo on the Grand Harbor.

In the Sicilian port of Messina, Aragon's newly appointed admiral Roger di Lauria was informed of the Angevin move and set off in pursuit. The Aragonese fleet was considered the best in the western Mediterranean. Its oarsmen were Sicilians in revolt against Angevin rule, and therefore highly motivated. Each galley carried 30 or 40 Catalan crossbowmen and some 50 *almogavers*—tough fighters recruited from wild areas of Spain bordering on Muslim territory.

WAR OF THE SICILIAN VESPERS



THE BATTLE OF MALTA

Date	July 8, 1283
Location	Grand Harbor, Valletta, Malta
Result	Aragonese victory

COMBATANTS

PETER III OF ARAGON	CHARLES OF ANJOU

COMMANDERS

Roger di Lauria	Bartolomé Bonvin Guillaume de Cornut

FORCES

Ships: 18 galleys	**Ships:** 19 galleys

LOSSES

Men: 300 **Ships:** none	**Men:** 3,500 **Ships:** 14 galleys

GIVE THE ENEMY A CHANCE

Di Lauria reached Malta on June 7. That night, under cover of darkness, he slipped an armed boat into the harbor to reconnoiter. It found the Angevin galleys beached with oars unshipped in a narrow inlet under the castle walls. Di Lauria decided to draw them out into the open harbor to fight. Sacrificing the chance to surprise a sleeping enemy, he announced his presence with a blast of trumpets. While the startled Angevins rushed to man and launch their galleys, di Lauria organized his fleet in line abreast across the harbor. Heavy cables were strung from galley to galley, making it impossible for enemy ships to pass between them.



Valletta harbor
The harbor today is still dominated by Fort St. Angelo. It retains its medieval appearance, but has been completely rebuilt since the time of Roger di Lauria.

At daybreak the Angevin galleys emerged into the harbor, their complement of marines augmented by a hundred armored knights from the castle. They deluged the Aragonese galleys in a hail of missiles—crossbow bolts, stones, javelins, darts, and pots containing a variety of substances from burning pitch to lime (intended to blind its victims). Di Lauria told his men to take cover and return fire only with crossbows. Ranging from heavy winched machines to light hand-held weapons spanned using a foot-stirrup, these were cruelly effective. A chronicler says the Catalan archers "did not discharge a shot without killing or disabling the man they attacked

When the Angevins had exhausted most of their supply of missiles, di Lauria ordered his galleys forward. They crashed into the prows of the enemy ships with a splintering shock. Then Aragonese missiles rained down on the enemy decks, including pots filled with soap that shattered, making the pitching decks treacherous for armored soldiers. The fierce *almogavers*, nimble and lightly clad in leather, sure-footedly stormed the Angevins' galleys. The Sicilian oarsmen joined in the fight, leaving their benches to take up sword and shield.

The Angevins were overwhelmed and slaughtered. Only a handful of their galleys evaded capture. Bonvin was among those who escaped, but de Cornut was killed along with the majority of those he commanded. Roger di Lauria had laid the foundations of his reputation as the greatest naval commander of his age.

Medieval Catalan galleys
This romantic image shows the ships crammed with *almogavers,* the troops that played such a vital role in the Aragonese victory at Malta.